

China Payment & Apps Setup Guide

A practical pre-arrival setup guide for Alipay, WeChat Pay, essential China apps, offline cards, and first-day payment backups.

www.firstchinatripkit.com
hello@firstchinatripkit.com
Last updated: July 2026

Use before you fly

Install apps, prepare cards, save addresses, and decide your payment backups before arrival.

Use on arrival day

Run a small payment test before relying on mobile payment for taxis, dinner, or train station snacks.

Use offline

Print or screenshot phrase cards, hotel cards, and the payment backup decision tree.

Important disclaimer and how to use this kit

This guide is a practical planning aid. It helps you prepare, test, and recover from common first-day payment and app issues.

Travel planning information only

This guide is not legal, immigration, financial, banking, or official government advice. Payment app support, card acceptance, verification rules, transport policies, and travel requirements may change. Always verify current official information before traveling.

Do not use this guide as	Use this guide as
A guarantee that an app, bank card, visa, route, or merchant payment will work.	A practical pre-trip checklist, worksheet, and offline backup pack.
A replacement for official app notices, bank card rules, immigration rules, or transport policies.	A way to organize what to verify before booking and before relying on payment apps.
A place to store passwords, full card numbers, or sensitive identity details.	A non-sensitive print pack for addresses, support numbers, and simple phrases.

Quick setup map

1 Install Alipay, WeChat, translation, map, mobile data, train support, and screenshot folder.	2 Prepare Passport, cards, bank app, SMS access, hotel address, cash, and physical card.	3 Save offline Hotel address, train bookings, phrase cards, bank support number, and arrival notes.	4 Test Make a small convenience-store purchase before relying on apps for taxis or dinner.
---	---	--	---

☐	Install Alipay and log in before departure.
☐	Add an international card if supported by your account and issuer.
☐	Install WeChat and attempt WeChat Pay setup if available.
☐	Prepare translation, map, eSIM or roaming, and train support apps.
☐	Save hotel name, Chinese address, phone, and nearest metro station offline.
☐	Carry small RMB cash and a physical bank card as backups.
☐	Do a small first-day payment test before depending on mobile payment.

Alipay setup worksheet

Section	What to prepare	If it does not work
Passport	Use the same passport name format if identity details are requested.	Keep passport accessible and avoid rushing verification in a queue.
International card	Add a card if supported by your account and card issuer.	Try another card, check bank app alerts, or use cash / physical card.
Phone number	Use a number you can access during travel.	Keep your home SIM available if bank SMS is needed.
Bank app	Confirm overseas card controls, security prompts, and transaction notices.	Notify your bank if your issuer recommends travel setup.
Stable internet	Use reliable Wi-Fi or mobile data during setup.	Do urgent purchases with a working backup first.
First-day payment test	Test with water or a small snack.	Do not make taxis or dinner your first test.
Common setup issues	Card declined, SMS not received, identity prompt, app language confusion.	Step aside, screenshot the prompt, and ask hotel staff if needed.

Careful wording

Alipay may work well for many foreign visitors, but support can depend on account status, card issuer, verification, app rules, and merchant flows. Prepare a backup.

WeChat and WeChat Pay backup worksheet

Topic	Useful for	Planning note
WeChat account	Messaging, local contact, service chats, and mini programs.	Install before arrival and confirm you can sign in.
WeChat Pay	Backup wallet and some restaurant or service payment flows.	Treat it as a backup until you have tested it.
Mini programs	Restaurants, attractions, ride-hailing, and services.	Some flows can be hard without Chinese support.
Setup friction	Foreign card support and verification can vary.	Do not make WeChat Pay your only payment option.
If setup fails	You can still use WeChat for communication if account access works.	Use Alipay first if it works, plus cash and physical card.
When WeChat helps	Hotel communication, local contacts, service counters, QR ordering.	Keep screenshots and translation ready if Chinese screens appear.

Backup role

WeChat is still useful even if WeChat Pay is not ready. Do not delete it just because payment setup is slow.

Payment backup decision tree

Alipay works Use it as primary. Still keep cash, physical card, and hotel address screenshots.	Alipay card fails Try another card. Check bank app alerts. Avoid repeated failed attempts at the counter.
WeChat Pay works Use it as backup for mini programs, restaurants, or merchants that expect WeChat.	App payment fails Reconnect data and retry once. Try a different QR flow. Then use backup payment.
Taxi payment fails Ask whether cash is possible. Show hotel phone number. Ask hotel staff for help if needed.	No internet Use offline hotel address, cash, physical card, and saved screenshots until data is restored.
Rule of thumb Pay with a working backup first. Debug app, card, or bank issues later, away from a taxi, restaurant line, or checkout counter.	

Essential China app stack

App / Tool	Chinese name	Main use	Install before arrival?	Friction	Backup tip
Alipay	支付宝	Payment, QR codes, ride-hailing, some services.	Yes	Medium	Carry card and cash.
WeChat	微信	Messaging, payment backup, mini programs.	Yes	Medium / High	Use Alipay first if needed.
Translation app	-	Text, voice, camera translation.	Yes	Low	Download offline Chinese.
Map app	-	Routes, addresses, transit.	Yes	Medium	Save screenshots.
eSIM / roaming app	-	Mobile data setup and support.	Yes	Medium	Keep hotel Wi-Fi plan.
Trip.com or train support	-	Train and hotel booking help.	Yes	Low / Medium	Save passport-linked tickets.
DiDi	滴滴	Ride-hailing.	Optional	Medium	Hotel can help call taxi.
Amap	高德地图	Local maps and transit.	Optional	High	Use screenshots or translation.
12306	中国铁路12306	Official train tickets.	Optional	High	Use booking platform or station help.
Offline screenshot folder	-	Addresses, tickets, payment notes.	Yes	Low	Keep available without data.

First-day payment test plan

1	2	3	4
Choose a low-stress shop	Buy something small	Test Alipay first	Confirm backup
Use a convenience store, cafe, or hotel lobby shop near your base.	Water or a snack keeps the amount low and the pressure low.	Try merchant QR and cashier scan if both are possible.	Check card charge, keep receipt if needed, and leave cash ready.

Good first test	Avoid as first test
A small purchase near your hotel, airport, or station.	Taxi fare, group dinner, attraction entry, or any queue where people are waiting behind you.
A staffed counter where you can step aside if needed.	A rushed self-service kiosk with weak mobile data.
A moment when your phone has battery and data.	Late night arrival with no cash, low battery, and no hotel help nearby.

Troubleshooting table

Problem	Possible reason	What to try	Backup
Card cannot be added	Issuer support, identity prompt, app rule, network issue.	Try another card, stable Wi-Fi, or bank app check.	Cash, physical card, hotel help.
SMS verification does not arrive	Roaming, SIM, spam filter, delay.	Wait, reconnect, check home SIM access.	Use another payment path.
Merchant says payment failed	QR flow, network, issuer block, merchant setting.	Try again once, lower amount, or another wallet.	Cash or physical card.
App asks for identity verification	Account rule or transaction risk check.	Read prompt carefully; avoid sharing sensitive data with strangers.	Use backup payment.
No internet after landing	Roaming/eSIM not active or airport coverage issue.	Use airport/hotel Wi-Fi and activation notes.	Cash, screenshots, hotel address.
Taxi cannot accept card	Taxi expects cash or QR payment.	Ask about cash before ride if possible.	Hotel call or ride-hailing app.
Restaurant only accepts QR payment	Ordering/payment inside QR or mini program.	Ask staff to help or order at cashier.	Choose simpler first meal.
Bank blocks transaction	Issuer fraud check or travel rule.	Open bank app or call support later.	Backup card or cash.

First-day scenario playbook

Airport arrival Test data before leaving the airport. Keep cash, hotel address, and transport screenshot ready.	Hotel check-in International hotels may prefer physical card pre-authorization. Keep passport and card accessible.
Taxi or ride-hailing Confirm pickup and destination in Chinese. If app payment fails, ask hotel or driver about cash.	Restaurant QR ordering If table QR is hard, ask staff for help or order at the cashier. Keep translation ready.
Train station Save station, train number, carriage, seat, passport-linked booking, and QR details offline.	Low battery Payment, maps, tickets, and translation all depend on your phone. Carry a charged power bank.

Useful Chinese payment phrases

English	Chinese characters	Pinyin
Can I pay with Alipay?	我可以用支付宝支付吗？	Wo keyi yong Zhifubao zhifu ma?
Can I pay with WeChat Pay?	可以用微信支付吗？	Keyi yong Weixin zhifu ma?
Can I pay by card?	可以刷卡吗？	Keyi shuaka ma?
Can I pay with cash?	可以用现金吗？	Keyi yong xianjin ma?
The payment failed.	支付失败了。	Zhifu shibai le.
Could you scan my QR code?	您可以扫我的付款码吗？	Nin keyi sao wo de fukuan ma?
Could you help me try again?	可以帮我再试一次吗？	Keyi bang wo zai shi yi ci ma?

How to use this page

Show the Chinese characters on your phone. Keep this page available offline in case translation apps or mobile data are not working.

Taxi and hotel phrase card

English	Chinese characters	Pinyin
Please help me call a taxi.	请帮我叫一辆出租车。	Qing bang wo jiao yi liang chuzuche.
This is my hotel address.	这是我的酒店地址。	Zhe shi wo de jiudian dizhi.
Please take me to this address.	请带我去这个地址。	Qing dai wo qu zhege dizhi.
Can I pay with cash?	可以用现金吗？	Keyi yong xianjin ma?
Please call my hotel.	请帮我联系酒店。	Qing bang wo lianxi jiudian.

Taxi note

If your destination is difficult to explain, show the Chinese address and hotel phone number. Hotel staff can often help confirm the destination before you leave.

Hotel address card template

Hotel address card

Cut out or screenshot this card. Do not write full card numbers, passwords, or bank login details.

Hotel English name	
Hotel Chinese name	
Chinese address	
Hotel phone	
Nearest metro station	
Emergency contact	
Notes	

Payment backup card

Payment backup card

Cut out or screenshot this card. Do not write full card numbers, passwords, or bank login details.

Primary payment	
Backup payment	
Small cash location	
Bank support number	
Hotel phone	
Cash phrase	可以用现金吗？ / Keyi yong xianjin ma? / Can I pay with cash?

Offline screenshot folder checklist

☐	Passport photo page copy stored securely and offline.
☐	Hotel Chinese name, address, phone, and nearest metro station.
☐	Train number, station name, carriage, seat, and passport-linked booking.
☐	Flight details, arrival airport, and onward transfer notes.
☐	Payment setup screenshots that do not expose full card numbers or passwords.
☐	Payment, taxi, hotel, and emergency phrase cards.
☐	Bank support number and travel insurance contact.
☐	A simple note titled: If my phone data fails, do this first.

Privacy note

Do not screenshot passwords, full card numbers, one-time codes, or recovery codes. Keep offline backups practical and non-sensitive.

Before you fly master checklist

Area	Ready check
Payment	Alipay installed; WeChat installed; card prepared; cash backup ready.
Apps	Translation, maps, ride-hailing, train support, and screenshot folder ready.
Internet	Roaming, eSIM, SIM, or pocket Wi-Fi plan confirmed.
Hotel address	Chinese name, address, phone, and nearest metro saved offline.
Train tickets	Passport-linked details and station names saved.
Passport	Passport accessible for hotel, trains, and tickets.
Cash	Small RMB backup carried safely.
Power bank	Charged and packed for payment and maps.
Emergency phrases	Payment, taxi, hotel, and cash phrases saved offline.

Official resources and verification log

Resource	What to verify
Alipay official resources	Current foreign card support, identity requirements, fees, and payment limits.
WeChat Pay official resources	Current foreign card support, wallet availability, verification, and usage limits.
China government payment guidance for overseas visitors	Current official visitor payment guidance and accepted methods.
Your own bank card issuer	Travel rules, fraud checks, overseas fees, SMS prompts, and card restrictions.
Hotel or travel provider	Address, payment options, deposit rules, local taxi or arrival help.

Verified item	Date checked	Note
Alipay card support		
WeChat Pay backup status		
Bank travel controls		
Hotel payment and deposit policy		
Mobile data plan		

Need more China trip help?

Next steps

Visit www.firstchinatripkit.com for city kits, itinerary kits, travel essentials, and free planning tools.

Resource	Where to go
City kits	Choose your first China base and save useful Chinese addresses.
Itinerary kits	Build routes that leave room for jet lag, transfers, and weather.
Travel essentials	Prepare visa, internet, train, food, safety, and basic Chinese notes.
Free tools	Use checklists, route pickers, and planning helpers.
Support	hello@firstchinatripkit.com

Thank you

Thanks for supporting First China Trip Kit. The guide stays practical, cautious, and focused on first-time visitors.